> [Jabar] really lost confidence and hope in us. In the conversation which he had with us, the topic turned to Shah Shuja ul-Mulk whose name we mentioned with great deference; on which the Nawab smiled, and said to the Envoy, 'If Shah Shuja is really a king, and come to the kingdom of his ancestors, what is the use of your army? You have brought him by your money and arms into Afghanistan, and you have behaved towards him in a friendly and liberal manner in every way. Leave him now with us Afghans, and let him rule us if he can.' Such plain language was not palatable to us . . . and the good Nawab, sunk in disappointment and distress of mind by our unfriendly manner towards him, left our camp about noon on the 29th July. I was told to escort the Nawab beyond our piquets; and on the road we heard the shrieks of some woman captured from the fortress of Ghazni. The Nawab turned his face towards me, and nodded his head . . . The tone of the language of the Nawab, on his return to Kabul, was not friendly towards us.[105]

As negotiations had now failed, Dost Mohammad had only one remaining option: he gathered his supporters in Kabul and summoned a public meeting in the gardens surrounding the unfinished tomb of Timur Shah. There he made an emotional speech, several accounts of which have survived. 'You have eaten my salt these last thirteen years,' he told his last followers. 'Grant me but one favour in return for that long period of maintenance and kindness – enable me to die with honour. Stand by the brother of Fatteh Khan while he executes one last charge against the cavalry of the Firangi dogs; if in that onset he will fall, then go and make your own terms with Shah Shuja.'[106] The plea was met with silence. The fullest account of what happened next is that given by Maulana Hamid Kashmiri in the *Akbarnama*, who has Dost Mohammad debate his own legitimacy with his followers. The Amir claims to represent the rule of Islamic law and justice, but his followers, seeing which way the wind is blowing, reply that a crowned and legitimate king should always have the first call on their loyalty, not an amir. For this reason they dismiss Dost Mohammad's argument that Shuja has lost the protection of law as he has chosen to ally himself with the Firangi infidels. 'What has the world become in these times?' asked the Amir.

> 'When of a hundred friends not one remains a friend?
>
> When men become more faithless than women
> Why then should the faith of women be given a bad name?
> I fear that the state will fall into the hand of the Firangis
> Then laws, a creed and religion of their own they would place here
>
> No one's honour would remain intact